

THE PLUG AI — WOODS FUND CHICAGO

Application Prep Plan + Draft Narrative

Target Cycle: February 2027 | Grant Amount: Up to \$35,000

REALITY CHECK

The 2026 cycle closed March 10. **Next window: February 2027.** This is not a setback — it's 9 months to build an application that actually wins.

A rushed application from a brand-new org with no 501(c)(3) and no organizing history would have been rejected. Use this time right.

THE FRAMING PIVOT (CRITICAL)

Woods Fund does NOT fund education programs or direct services. They fund **community organizing movements**.

The Plug AI must show up as a MOVEMENT, not a training platform.

The Organizing Frame for The Plug AI:

The injustice: Black, Brown, and low-income communities in Chicago are being systematically excluded from the AI economy. AI is not a neutral technology — it is being designed, deployed, and monetized by institutions that have never included these communities. The result is a new form of structural exclusion: the AI wealth gap.

The base: Directly impacted BIPOC residents of Chicago's South and West sides, Park Forest, and surrounding Cook County communities who are being locked out of AI-driven jobs, services, and economic opportunity.

The demand: Equitable AI access and literacy as a civil right. Specifically:

- AI literacy integration in Chicago's public institutions (libraries, schools, workforce centers)
- Corporate accountability for equitable AI hiring pipelines

- City of Chicago policy requiring AI equity impact assessments
- State-level policy advocacy for Illinois digital equity restoration

The target: Corporate employers and policymakers who control AI workforce pipelines, public school systems and workforce boards that have failed to integrate AI literacy, and tech companies building AI systems that perpetuate racial bias.

The organization: The Plug AI is a majority BIPOC-led, community-rooted organizing effort that uses AI education as the entry point to build a base of people who understand their exclusion and are ready to demand change.

ELIGIBILITY CHECKLIST (What You Need by Feb 2027)

Requirement	Status	Action
Chicago metro / Cook County based	✅ Park Forest, IL	Done
501(c)(3) or fiscal sponsor	❌ Needed	See Month 1 below
Majority BIPOC-led	✅ Stefan as founder	Document + communicate
Community organizing (not just services)	🟡 Needs framing	Use this document
Racial equity framework	✅ Core to mission	Articulate explicitly
Base-building activity	🟡 Build it	Start workshops as base-building

9-MONTH PREPARATION TIMELINE

MONTHS 1-2 | MAY – JUNE 2026: STRUCTURE

- Secure fiscal sponsor OR begin 501(c)(3) incorporation
 - Best fiscal sponsor options for The Plug AI in Chicago:
 - Crossroads Fund (funds radical orgs; already partners with Woods Fund)
 - Forefront Illinois (statewide nonprofit umbrella)

- Technology in the Public Interest (tech equity focus)

- ☐ Email Brittany Ward (brittany@woodsfund.org) NOW:
 - Introduce The Plug AI, say you're preparing for the 2027 cycle
 - Ask: "Are there capacity-building resources available for orgs preparing to apply?"
 - This builds relationship BEFORE the application
 - ☐ Sign up for Woods Fund Chicago mailing list:
 - signup.e2ma.net/signup/1944650/1730579/
 - ☐ Research past Woods Fund grantees (2023-2025 annual reports)
 - Understand their portfolio so you can show you ADD to it, not duplicate it
 - ☐ Write your founding story / organizational narrative (first draft)
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MONTHS 3-4 | JULY – AUGUST 2026: BASE-BUILDING

- ☐ Host first 3 AI literacy workshops – but frame and document as BASE-BUILDING:
 - Track: who attended, demographics, what they said, what they want changed
 - Have attendees sign up for The Plug AI "movement" (not just a mailing list)
 - Capture testimonials: "How has being left out of AI impacted your life?"
 - ☐ Begin building your COALITION:
 - Partner with 2-3 churches (you already have BigHeart Health church network)
 - Partner with 1 community organization (community center, library, block club)
 - These are your "base-building partners" – name them in your application
 - ☐ Identify your specific TARGETS:
 - Which Chicago employer is hiring AI workers but not from your community?
 - Which alderman or city council member has jurisdiction over workforce policy?
 - Which institution should be doing AI literacy training but isn't?
 - Name them specifically – Woods Fund wants to see you know who holds power
 - ☐ Begin documenting EVERYTHING:
 - Photos, attendance lists, testimonial videos, flyers, social media engagement
 - This becomes your "organizational track record" in the application
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MONTHS 5-6 | SEPTEMBER – OCTOBER 2026: DEMANDS & CAMPAIGN

- ☐ Develop your POLICY DEMAND:

- Draft a 1-page "AI Equity Demand" for the City of Chicago or Cook County
- Example: "We demand the City of Chicago require all public libraries to offer free AI literacy programming in underserved zip codes by 2028"
- This demand is what separates organizing from service delivery

☐ Take first COLLECTIVE ACTION:

- Community town hall where base members speak publicly about the AI exclusion
- Letter-writing campaign to a city official or employer
- Presentation at a school board or aldermanic meeting
- Even ONE action documented = proof of organizing, not just programming

☐ Write your Theory of Change:

- "We believe that when BIPOC communities in Chicago understand AI and are organized around AI equity, they gain power to demand inclusion from the institutions that have excluded them."

☐ Build your organizational infrastructure:

- Website live
- Social media presence showing community engagement (not just content)
- Board or advisory committee (at least 3 people from the community)

MONTHS 7-8 | NOVEMBER – DECEMBER 2026: APPLICATION PREP

☐ Draft full application narrative (use templates below)

☐ Gather organizational documents:

- 501(c)(3) determination letter OR fiscal sponsor agreement
- Most recent financial statements OR projected budget
- List of board/advisory members
- Organizational chart

☐ Request letters of support from:

- At least 2 community organizations you've partnered with
- At least 1 community member (not a professional – a neighbor, a church member)

☐ Review past Woods Fund grantee organizations' public profiles

- Make sure your application language shows you KNOW the field

☐ Have someone outside your org read your application cold

- Can they explain what you do, who you serve, and what you're demanding?

MONTH 9 | JANUARY 2027: FINAL PREP

- ☐ Portal opens February 10 — be READY to submit Day 1
- ☐ Have Brittany Ward review your draft if she's offered that feedback
- ☐ Proofread every section three times
- ☐ Submit before the March 10 deadline

DRAFT APPLICATION NARRATIVE

Use these as drafts — refine based on your actual activities by February 2027

SECTION 1: Organization Description

Draft:

The Plug AI is a Chicago-area community organizing effort founded by Stefan [Last Name], a Black educator, tech professional, and lifelong South Side community member. We build power in Black, Brown, and low-income communities in Chicago and Cook County by organizing around AI equity — the growing crisis of BIPOC communities being systematically excluded from the artificial intelligence economy.

We operate at the intersection of technology and racial justice. As AI reshapes hiring, education, healthcare, and civic life, Black and Brown Chicagoans are being left out of the design, deployment, and benefits of these systems. Our work is not a training program — it is a movement. We use AI literacy as the foundation for base-building, identifying the institutional targets responsible for this exclusion, and organizing our community to make collective demands for change.

The Plug AI is majority BIPOC-led and rooted in the communities most impacted by AI exclusion. Our founder's networks span church communities, workforce development organizations, and educational institutions across Chicago's South Side and south suburban Cook County. We are building a base of directly impacted people who are ready to turn AI awareness into AI power.

SECTION 2: Community Organizing Strategy

Draft:

The Problem We're Organizing Around: AI is the defining economic force of the next decade. Corporate employers in Chicago's Loop and along the tech corridor are actively building AI-powered hiring systems, customer service tools, and workforce

pipelines — while simultaneously failing to hire, train, or include Black and Brown workers in these roles. Public institutions — the Chicago Public Library, CPS, and the City’s workforce development centers — have not integrated AI literacy programming at scale. The result: a city where some residents are mastering AI tools and building wealth, while others — disproportionately BIPOC — are being replaced by systems they’ve never seen.

Our Base: We are building a base of Black, Brown, and low-income residents across Chicago’s South Side and south suburban Cook County. These are workers, parents, church community members, seniors, and young people who are experiencing the impact of AI exclusion firsthand — and who, when equipped and organized, are powerful advocates for change. Through workshops, community events, and digital organizing, we are developing leaders within our base who connect their personal experience to systemic injustice and are ready to take action.

Our Target: We identify and organize around specific decision-makers who have the power to change conditions for our community: elected officials who shape digital equity policy at the city and state level; employers who build AI-powered hiring systems without equitable access pipelines; and public institutions like the Chicago Public Library system and CPS that control educational infrastructure but have failed to prioritize AI literacy for underserved communities.

Our Demand: We are building toward specific, winnable policy and institutional demands, including: AI literacy integration as a standard offering at all Chicago Public Library branches in South Side zip codes; transparent AI hiring equity reporting requirements for Chicago-area employers; and restoration and expansion of Illinois state funding for digital equity programming.

Our Actions: [Describe the specific actions your base has taken — town halls, letter campaigns, presentations to decision-makers, petitions. Fill this in with your actual activities by the time you submit.]

SECTION 3: Racial Equity Framework

Draft:

The Plug AI centers a racial justice framework in everything we do. The AI equity gap is not a skills gap — it is a power gap. When AI systems are designed without Black and Brown input, when AI-powered hiring screens out BIPOC candidates, when AI literacy resources are concentrated in wealthy and predominantly white communities, these are not accidents. They are the digital extension of structural racism.

Our work is rooted in the belief that technology is not neutral. Our organizing equips community members not just to use AI tools, but to understand who controls AI, who benefits from it, and how to collectively demand that those systems serve — not harm — our communities. We use an intersectional framework that recognizes the compounding barriers faced by women of color, immigrants, formerly incarcerated individuals, seniors, and others at the intersection of multiple systems of exclusion.

As a majority BIPOC-led organization led by someone who comes from the communities we serve, we are not bringing solutions to these communities — we are activating solutions that already exist within them.

SECTION 4: Budget Narrative (Sample — \$35,000 Grant)

Line Item	Amount	Notes
Founder/Executive Director (part-time)	\$18,000	50% FTE — base-building, organizing, facilitation
Community Outreach Coordinator (PT)	\$8,000	Event support, base-building outreach
Workshop Materials & Supplies	\$2,500	Devices, print materials, tech supplies
Community Events & Convenings	\$2,500	Space rental, food, transportation
Technology & Platform Costs	\$2,000	Website, design tools, AI tools for workshops
Communications & Outreach	\$2,000	Flyers, social media, community media
TOTAL	\$35,000	

THE RELATIONSHIP MOVE TO MAKE THIS WEEK

Before the portal opens in February, relationships matter more than the application.

Email to send NOW to Brittany Ward:

Subject: New Org Preparing for 2027 Cycle — The Plug AI

Hi Brittany,

My name is Stefan [Last Name], and I'm the founder of The Plug AI, a community organizing effort based in Cook County focused on AI equity for Black and Brown communities in Chicago.

I learned about Woods Fund Chicago through your website and was moved by your commitment to trust-based philanthropy and grassroots organizing. We missed the 2026 window, so I'm beginning to prepare in earnest for the 2027 cycle.

I'd love to ask: Are there capacity-building resources, convenings, or pre-application guidance available for organizations in our stage? I want to make sure we're showing up to the portal in February as well-prepared as possible — not just with paperwork, but with the organizing track record your program looks for.

Thank you for your work and for the resources you make available to the field.

Stefan [Last Name] Founder, The Plug AI [Phone] | [Email] | [Website]

Contacts:

- **Brittany Ward** (Grants & Administrative Manager): brittany@woodsfund.org
 - **Main office:** 312.600.0948
 - **Address:** 200 W Madison St, 3rd Floor, Chicago, IL 60606
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WHAT MAKES WOODS FUND APPLICATIONS WIN

Based on their funding history and stated values:

1. **The founder IS the community.** Stefan being a Black South Side/south suburban Chicago resident isn't a detail — it's the headline. Say it explicitly.
2. **Name your target.** Vague applications fail. "We organize against systemic AI exclusion" is weak. "We are organizing BIPOC residents to demand that Chicago Public Libraries offer free AI literacy in the 14 South Side zip codes with the lowest tech access" is a winner.
3. **Show your base is real.** Numbers, testimonials, demographics. Who showed up to your events? What did they say? What are they ready to do?
4. **Connect to the movement.** Woods Fund funds movement infrastructure. Show that

you know other organizations in the AI equity space and how you connect to — or fill a gap in — the existing movement in Chicago.

5. **General operating support ask.** Woods Fund gives general operating support (not project grants). They're funding YOUR ORGANIZATION, not a specific program. Your narrative should make them want to invest in Stefan and The Plug AI as a growing force — not just one workshop series.

*Prepared by Kai for The Plug AI | May 2026 Woods Fund Chicago: woodsfund.org |
Apply: February 10, 2027*